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WORDS OF DHAMMA	
Samahito sampajano, sato Buddhassa savako Vedana ca pajanati, vedananam ca sambhavam. Yattha ceta nirujjhanti, Maggam ca khayagaminam Vedananam khaya, bhikkhu nicchato parinibbuto ti. - Samyutta-nikaya IV, Nal. 183, PTS 204	A follower of the Buddha, with concentration, awareness and constant thorough understand impermanence, knows with wisdom the sensa their arising, their cessation and the path lead their end. A meditator who has reached the er all sensations (stage of Nibbana) is freed from craving, fully liberated.

THE ESSENTIALS OF BUDDHA DHAMMA IN MEDITATIVE PRACTICE

By Sayagyi U Ba Khin

(This year marks the twentieth anniversary of the demise of Sayagyi U Ba Khin. He passed away on 19 January 1971. Several years before he died, Sayagyi composed the following discourse in English particularly for his Western students. He read it to students on a number of occasions. After his death, the discourse was transcribed and published under the above title. The following is an excerpt.)

Let me now deal with Vipassana meditation from the point of view of a householder in everyday life and explain the benefit one can derive from it-here and now-in this very lifetime.

The initial object of Vipassana meditation is to activate the experience of anicca in oneself and eventually to reach a state of inner and outer calmness and balance. This is achieved when one becomes engrossed in the feeling of anicca within. The world is now facing serious problems, which threaten all mankind. It is just the right time for everyone to take to Vipassana meditation and learn how to find a deep pool of quiet in the midst of all that is happening today. Anicca is inside of everybody. It is within reach of everybody. Just a look into oneself and there it is-anicca to be experienced. When one can feel anicca, when one can experience anicca, and when one can become engrossed in anicca, one can at will cut oneself off from the world of ideation outside. Anicca is, for the householder, the gem of life, which he will treasure to create a reservoir of calm and balanced energy for his own well-being and for the welfare of society.

The experience of anicca, when properly developed, strikes at the root of one's physical and mental ills and removes gradually whatever is bad in him, i.e., the causes of such physical and mental ills. This experience is not reserved for men who have renounced the world for the homeless life. It is for the householder as well. In spite of drawbacks which make a householder restless in these days, a competent teacher or guide can help a student to get the experience of anicca activated in a comparatively short time. Once he has got it activated, all that is necessary is for him to try to preserve it; but he must make it a point, as soon as time or opportunity presents itself for further progress, to work for the stage of bhanganana

(knowledge of bhanga)-the third level of knowledge in Vipassana. If he reaches this level, there will be little or no problem because he should then be able to experience annica without much ado and almost automatically. In this case anicca will become his base, to which all his physical and mental activities return as soon as the domestic needs of daily life for such activities are over. However, there is likely to be some difficulty for one who has not reached the stage of bhanga. It will be just like a tug-of-war for him between anicca within, and physical and mental activities outside. So it would be wise for him to follow the motto of “Work while you work, play while you play.” There is no need for him to be activating the experience of anicca all the time. It should suffice if this could be confined to a regular period, or periods, set apart in the day or night for the purpose. During this time, at least, an attempt must be made to keep the attention focused inside the body, with awareness devoted exclusively to anicca. That is to say, his awareness of anicca should go on from moment to moment so continuously as not to allow for the interpolation of any discursive or distracting thoughts, which are definitely detrimental to progress. In case this is not possible, he will have to go back to respiration-mindfulness, because samadhi is the key to the contemplation of anicca. To get good samadhi, sila (morality) has to be perfect, since samadhi is built upon sila. For a good experience of anicca, samadhi must be good. If samadhi is excellent, awareness of anicca will also become excellent.

There is no special technique for activating the experience of anicca other than the use of the mind adjusted to a perfect state of balance, and attention projected upon the object of meditation. In Vipassana the object of meditation is anicca, and therefore in the case of those used to focusing their attention on bodily feelings, they can feel anicca directly. In experiencing anicca in relation to the body, it should first be in the area where one can easily get his attention engrossed, changing the area of attention from place to place, from head to feet and from feet to head, at times probing into the interior. At this stage, it must clearly be understood that no attention is to be paid to the anatomy of the body, but to the formations of matter-the kalapas-and the nature of their constant change.

If these instructions are observed, there will surely be progress, but the progress depends also on parami (i.e., one's disposition for certain spiritual qualities) and devotion of the individual to the work of meditation. If he attains high levels of knowledge, his power to understand the three characteristics of anicca, dukkha and anatta will increase and he will accordingly come nearer and nearer to the goal of the ariya or noble saint-which every householder should keep in view.

This is the age of science. Man of today has no utopia. He will not accept anything unless the results are good, concrete, vivid, personal, and here-and-now. When the Buddha was alive, he said to the people of Kalama: “Now look, you Kalamas. Be not misled by report or tradition or hearsay. Be not misled by proficiency in the scriptural collections, or by reasoning or logic, or reflection on and approval of some theory, or because some view conforms with one's inclinations, or out of respect for the prestige of a teacher. But when you know for yourselves: these things are unwholesome, these things are blameworthy, these things are censured by the wise; these things, when practised and observed, conduce to loss and sorrow-then do ye reject them. But if at any time you know for yourselves: these things are wholesome, these things are blameless, these things are praised by the intelligent; these things, when practised and observed, conduce to welfare and happiness-then, Kalamas, do ye, having practised them, abide.”

The time-clock of Vipassana has now struck-that is, for the revival of Buddha-Dhamma Vipassana in practice. We have no doubt whatsoever that definite results would accrue to

those who would with an open mind sincerely undergo a course of training under a competent teacher-I mean results which will be accepted as good, concrete, vivid, personal, here-and-now-results which will keep them in good stead and in a state of well-being and happiness for the rest of their lives.

May all beings be happy and may peace prevail in the world. ?

Sayagyi, it seems to me that it was all a previous existence, and that having received Dhamma from him, I entered a new life, far superior to the old one, the Dhamma words come to mind:

Yam kinci vittam idha vahuram va

Saggesu va yam ratanam panitam

Na no samam atthi Tathagatena

Idampi Buddhe ratanam panitam

Idampi Dhamme ratanam panitam

Idampi Sanghe ratanam panitam

Whatever treasure there may be in this world or the next,

Whatever jewels may be found even in the celestial fields,

None of these can compare with the jewel in the Tathagata*

-the jewel in the Tathagata is far higher.

This is the jewel in the Teacher.

This is the jewel in the Teaching.

This is the jewel in the followers of the Teaching.

All the wealth I had amassed, whether here in Burma or here in India, could give me merely earthly pleasures. All the merits I had gained by giving service before I learned Dhamma might have given me a new life in celestial planes. There I might have enjoyed still greater pleasures. But all these pleasures, earthly or celestial, would be ephemeral-bound to pass away-and must lead to disappointment and misery when they go. They are nothing compared to the happiness I have got in receiving the jewel of Dhamma from my teacher-a happiness which keeps growing everyday in my life.

- S.N.Goenka

* Literally, ‘thus-gone' or ‘thus-come'. One who by walking on the path of reality has reached ultimate reality, i.e. an enlightened person. The term by which the Buddha commonly referred to himself.

BEARING THE TORCH OF DHAMMA

The time has ripened for the spread of Dhamma, to help many come out of misery. We are fortunate to have the opportunity to help others in Dhamma. By doing so we help ourselves develop our own paramis (wholesome qualities) in order to reach the goal of liberation. There is no greater service than Dhamma service, since it enables miserable people to go to the root of their problems and emerge from all sufferings. Whatever the service one gives-whether guiding others in Dhamma or providing for their physical needs-its value depends only on the volition with which it is given. The most exalted task is worthless if performed with arrogance. The most menial task is invaluable if performed with humility and love. Therefore the base of service must be the actual practice of Dhamma in order to ensure the proper results.

Those who serve must bear in mind that they exemplify to new comers the efficacy of the Dhamma. If they are devoid of good qualities, they will discourage others from practicing the Dhamma. They have a great responsibility to see that their behaviour inspires confidence in Dhamma in those who were doubtful, and greater faith where it already exists.

Whoever serves must become strongly established in Dhamma, and as one does so, all attachments to sects, philosophies, and rituals are left behind. One then sees that Dhamma is a way of life. Living in peace with oneself and with all others. Our actions must be pure, and this is possible only when the mind is freed of defilements such as anger, hatred, passion, and ill-will. When these are eliminated, good qualities naturally arise in the mind: love, compassion, good-will. This is Dhamma-a universal path.

The aim of Dhamma is to remove the roots of defilement from the mind. Through practice, one soon realizes what the root is, where suffering actually begins: in reactions of craving or aversion to sensations within the body. If one learns to maintain equanimity with the wisdom of anicca (impermanence), one emerges from the unhealthy habit of reacting, and the entire mass of the mind is purified.

Understanding this, one will practice properly, and give importance only to the essence of Dhamma, and not to external, superficial matters. And the service of such a person will be with the volition of helping as many people as possible-whoever they may be-to come out of suffering and attain peace. The results of this service will be wonderful.

No one serving Dhamma should feel superior or inferior to others. Whatever the task assigned, one should accept it happily as an opportunity to serve for the benefit of many, to bring a smile to faces that were tearful, to foster peace where before there was none.

We serve merely for the sake of serving, without expecting anything in return. And the result will be to create an atmosphere of love, good-will and purity, which will help those who come now, and in later generations, to grasp the Dhamma and find real peace.

Therefore, Dhamma service is an extraordinary opportunity. Perform it to liberate yourselves and to help others be liberated from defilements, from bondages, from misery. Be the

torchbearers of the Dhamma to dispel the surrounding darkness of ignorance and suffering.

May you be strong to serve suffering beings everywhere. May all miserable people come into contact with the Dhamma and be liberated. May you all keep practicing Dhamma, for your own good and for the good of many.

May all beings be happy!

- S. N.Goenka

1. I have given you ANICCA as the Dhamma for refuge. For so long as you are with ANICCA, you are with me. ANICCA when properly developed will solve almost all your problems. It might not even be necessary for you to ask questions for answers. As the appreciation of ANICCA grows, so will the veil of ignorance fade away. When the way becomes clear for the Right Understanding, doubts and fears will disappear automatically. You will then see things in the true perspective.

2. There is no cause without an effect and there is no effect without a cause. The law of KAMMA (moral causation) is supreme and inevitable. What you have now is the result of what you have done in the past. Until we get rid of the forces of KAMMA which belong to us once and for all, and enter the supreme NIBBaNA, there is bound to be some trouble or other, here and there, during the remainder of our existence which we must put up with, using the strength of ANICCA (impermanence).

ANICCA will surely prevail upon them and you will keep yourself in good stead inspite of all these. ANICCA is power. Thorns in the way are inevitable. Make use of the power of ANICCA with diligence and there will be peace with you.

- Sayagyi U Ba Khin